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A LONG LONG TIME AGO

SCENE 0: THUNDERSTORM DOWN SOUTH

Flashes of a thunderstorm - Flashes of a mother playing with her son - and building bird houses - flashes of wind hitting the yoooo breeze in the mountains - and flashes of a vacation up north - up towards new england - flashes of a seaside beach town - flashes of a big thunderstorm - flashes of the mom and the dog driving doing errands - flashes of Dallas setting up an instrument and pointing it towards the sky - flashes of Mac helping him - flashes of the woods - flashes of the dark grass - flashes of the mother coming back and running away from the dog - towards the light -

Flashes of a funeral.

VO MAC

Life doesn't seem to control anything - just not the way that light does. The man from the funeral home had a nephew who was slow - he was showing me off wrestling magazines and talked about how life throws the lemons at the champion and the champion always squashes the lemons - I nodded but later have come to think about this quote often - life throwing things at me - what is life? Does life have a mind? Does life make decisions? What does that mean?

I went on the internet that night and found that quote

scattered everywhere. But then I realized that I was wrong in the looking.

SATURDAY

SCENE 1: EXT. WINDY SEASIDE ROAD - DAY

DALLAS (40s) and his son *MAC* (10) drive along a winding seaside road. The rugged coastline stretches beside them, with Atlantic waves crashing against the rocks. A storm brews in the distance, dark clouds gathering on the horizon.

As they drive the radio is on and the newscaster is almost excited to announce that there is a storm coming and that we are about to enter hurricane season.

SCENE 2: EXT. NEW HOUSE - SOUTHERN CONNECTICUT COAST - DAY

Dallas signs papers on a clipboard handed to him by a *MOVER*. The Movers begin unloading boxes from the truck.

Nearby, a *TV CAMERAMAN* and a *CAMERA CREW* capture a *REPORTER* speaking into the camera. *Mac* watches from a distance, curious and uncertain about the commotion.

SCENE 3: EXT. NEW HOUSE - DRIVEWAY - DAY

Dallas and *Mac* unload various items from a bucket in the back of their sedan. Among the items are an unfinished bird feeder and gardening tools.

Dallas pauses, staring somberly at the bucket. His emotions overwhelm for a moment.

SCENE 4: INT. NEW HOUSE - MAC'S ROOM - DUSK

Mac stands by the window, gazing out at the dimming light. Fireflies flicker in the tall grass. As the wind sways the branches, the fireflies' lights resemble the glint of eyes peering from the darkness.

Mac glances up at the sky - it is clear.

SCENE 5: INT. KITCHEN - NIGHT

Dallas carefully plates an avocado, an onion, and a sliced lemon—meticulously into small pieces and then reassembled to appear untouched. His movements are deliberate, almost ritualistic.

Mac sets the table and turns on the TV. He flips through channels until he finds the local weather report.

ON TV: The same *REPORTER* from earlier, standing outside their house, discusses the unpredictable weather this time of year.

REPORTER

As you can see behind me, new residents are moving in despite the ominous weather forecast. Meteorologists are predicting an unusually severe storm system to hit our coast within the couple of weeks hours. That's right folks - we're in for a wild ride.

Dallas moves closer to the TV, his expression growing concerned as he listens to the report.

REPORTER

(Interviewing the Mayor in a Podcast style setting) Residents are advised always be ready in case of an emergency - stock up on the basics - essentials and prepare for potential power outages. Stay tuned for further updates on this developing situation.

Mac's eyes drift back to the window, where the wind has picked up, rustling the tall grass outside.

SCENE 6: EXT. NEW HOUSE - NIGHT

Thunder rumbles in the distance, and the wind causes the storm approaches.

FADE OUT.

SUNDAY

SCENE 7: INT. CHURCH - MORNING

The *PASTOR* stands at the pulpit, addressing the congregation. The church is filled with attentive listeners, including *DALLAS* (40s) and *MAC* (10), sitting quietly in a pew.

PASTOR

According to the book of Isiah - David - today we are going to look at a new passage from the new testament - and ask why we call it the new testament. Is the old testament that much older? Have people changed that much? During ancient times, Israelites would make sacrifices of all kinds--grain, animals, even blood. But today, we know that blood sacrifice is no longer required.

The sermon concludes. The congregation begins to stir as they prepare to leave.

SCENE 8: EXT. CHURCH FELLOWSHIP AREA - AFTERNOON

The church bustles with activity as congregates gather and plop iceberg lettuce on their plastic plates. *Dallas* and *Mac* stand awkwardly, each holding a plate of food. They stare at their plates, struggling to feel at ease.

A *FRIENDLY MAN* (50s), noticing their discomfort, approaches them with a welcoming smile.

FRIENDLY MAN

Hey there, - hey (hey) where y'all from?

DALLAS

Indiana.

FRIENDLY MAN

Indiana, huh? Never been - Well, welcome - Where are you living now?

DALLAS

Branford.

The Friendly Man's face lights up.

FRIENDLY MAN

No way! I'm in Branford too! We have a BBQ going on tomorrow for Labor Day. Come through if you can.

Dallas nods politely, but he and Mac still seem out of place.

In the distance, Mac spots MOLLY (12) and ASHER (10) huddled over something. Asher holds a bunch of gear, while Molly waves what looks like weather instruments in the air.

The Friendly Man points toward a MINI FRIDGE near the coffee machine. A flyer pinned to the fridge reads: "23rd Annual Branford Harvest Sea Festival."

Dominic enters the scene - giving a nod to the friendly man.

DOMINIC

See that? My cousin's in charge of the whole thing. It's the Sea Festival--a big deal around here. We do it every year to raise money for the Little League.

(MORE)

DOMINIC (CONT'D)

Borrow some stage equipment from the big arenas, get some local swashbuckle and jam bands to play... and of course, oysters for days. Not as famous as the Oyster Festival, but we hold our own.

Dallas listens politely, nodding along, but his attention drifts as the man continues to rattle on.

Makayla and Asher put something in a bag and put it under a tree. Mac doesn't say anything.

SCENE 9: EXT. BRANFORD STREETS - EARLY EVENING

Dallas and Mac walk home from church. The journey is a bit of a hike. They pass through the tall beech grass, a little pizzeria, a small post office, a free library mail post, and a mix of nice homes with boats docked nearby--some pristine, others not so much.

SCENE 10: EXT. MAC AND DALLAS HOUSE - BUTTERFLY LANE

They continue past it all, into their corner of the world--a quiet cul-de-sac near a land preserve and a bird sanctuary.

They finally arrive home, exhausted, taking in the sight of their new house as the wind begins to pick up.

The two look around at the property - and the property looks back at them.

Dallas peers in the distance at a kind of torn outdoor shed - he lifts peers the door open - and looks past all of the cobwebs and overgrown marsh that has entered it - he flicks the light switch - nothing.

Mac runs in the backyard and checks out the mailbox - which is irregular and begins to open.

SCENE 11: INT. NEW HOUSE - MAC'S ROOM - NIGHT

Later that night, *Mac* looks out his bedroom window. The fireflies are out again, their soft glow dotting the landscape. The wind rustles the tall grass outside, making the fireflies flicker and blur.

As *Mac* focuses on the distance, the fireflies' lights begin to resemble eyes watching from the darkness, unsettling him.

MONDAY

SCENE 12: INT. SEDAN - MORNING

Dallas closes the garage door of a makeshift outdoor workshop. *DALLAS*, holding his phone with the latest iOS, follows Google Maps as they drive through town in their old sedan. The car's engine hums steadily as they approach the school. *DALLAS* glances at *MAC* (10), who sits quietly in the passenger seat, a mix of nervousness and anticipation on his face.

DALLAS

Hope you have a good day.

Mac nods, gripping his backpack tightly as they pull up to the school.

SCENE 13: EXT. SCHOOL ENTRANCE - MORNING

Mac steps out of the sedan, looking up at the imposing structure of his new school. The sounds of chattering students and the ringing of the school bell fill the air. *Dallas* watches him from the car before driving off.

SCENE 14: INT. CLASSROOM - MORNING

Mac enters the classroom, glancing around nervously at the unfamiliar faces. He finds an empty seat and sits down, trying to blend in.

The *TEACHER*, a man in his early 30s, stands at the front of the room, beginning his introduction.

TEACHER

TEACHER

(Sheepishly) Hello everyone. Good morning, everyone. Welcome to class - my name is Mr. ### and I am your 5th grade science teacher - .

(noticing a distracted student) Hey, you paying attention?

(continuing)

This semester, we'll be exploring the wonders world of-weather patterns, the phases of the moon, and count all of the ripples of the tides... We'll then move on and examine different ways in which the phases of the moon rile together. In a chasm of solar gravity - moon beams. the tides work.

Mac listens intently, but his attention is soon drawn to the window. Outside, the sky is overcast, and a field of wetlands with tall grass stretches out beyond the schoolyard.

SCENE 15: EXT. SCHOOL YARD - AFTERNOON

Mac sees ASHER (10) from afar, accompanied by MOLLY (12), the same girl from church. Molly hands Asher a bag, and Asher discreetly puts it in his backpack. Mac watches the exchange, his curiosity piqued.

SCENE 16: INT. SEDAN - AFTERNOON

Dallas picks up Mac after school. As they drive home, they realize that Asher and MAKAYLA are their neighbors. The TALKATIVE NEIGHBOR from church approaches their car, greeting them enthusiastically.

DOMINIC TALKATIVE NEIGHBOR

My Lord Indiana! Check you out big guy! Hey, Indiana!
Look at us - we're neighbors! These kids are
neighbors! Small world, huh?

Makayla walks behind her father into frame and walks right up to Mac. a group of neighborhood kids approaches Mac, one of them, a GIRL (10), speaks up.

MAKAYLA

Did you see me give Asher that bag?

MAC

Yeah.

MAKAYLA

You Did?

MAC

Yeah.

*Asher, looking sheepish, quickly walks away back to the house.
Molly approaches Mac, looking him up and down.*

MAKAYLA

Can I trust you?

MAC

Yeah.

*Molly glances over at Dallas and the Talkative Neighbor, then
back to Mac.*

MAKAYLA

Ask your dad if it's okay for you to come over after
dinner tonight. If so - I'll tell Asher and he'll meet
you outside with a bike.

MAC

I have a bike.

Mac nods._

MAKAYLA

Good.

Makayla turns and walks away, disappearing into the crowd.

Mac looks over at his dad - who is still talking to Dominic - and then back to the retreating figure of Makayla.

SCENE 17: EXT. MOLLY'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Molly opens up the bag, revealing crab meat and bits of chicken in some tiny zip locks. She hands some to Mac, along with sticks and string. The kids spend the night trying to lure something out in the wetlands, but nothing happens. A thunderstorm begins to brew, and the wind howls around them.

Suddenly, Molly's MOTHER calls her home, and the kids quickly pack up.

SCENE 18: INT. NEW HOUSE - MAC'S ROOM - NIGHT

That night, Mac looks out his bedroom window. The thunderstorm rages outside, the wind shaking the trees and tall grass. The power flickers, then goes out. Mac stares into the darkness, his eyes wide as he hears a loud crash from outside.

He presses his face closer to the glass, trying to make out what caused the noise, but all he can see are the blurred, glowing fireflies--now resembling eyes watching him through the storm.

FADE OUT.

TUESDAY

SCENE 19: EXT. HOUSE - TUESDAY MORNING

The morning sun casts long shadows as DALLAS steps outside, carrying a trash bag. He walks towards the bins, inspecting

them for any sign of raccoons - he looks a bit puzzled at the far distance of the grasslands that surround their home.

In the distance, *MAC* (10) sprints towards the mailbox, eager to grab the mail. As he opens the mailbox, he notices something unusual: a small burn mark on the ground. It's not large or round, but scattered and irregular.

Dallas notices *Mac's* hesitation and walks over, peering down at the mark.

Dallas frowns slightly but doesn't comment further. *Mac* collects the mail, and they head to the car.

Mac looks down - next to the lightning mark there is a single gemstone laying on the ground. *Mac* doesn't touch it - but goes into the car.

SCENE 20: INT. CLASSROOM - DAY

The classroom buzzes with chatter as the *TEACHER* begins the day's lesson.

TEACHER

For those who were up last night, some of you may have the faint clap of a heard a distant rolling thunder - but what causes that? What causes these phonemeonms that allow us to get wild throughout the night? *The teacher throws a book on the ground*

TEACHER

I'm talking about boom thunder! And how long does thunder make a sound after lightning? Wake up people these are life long anecdotes! Today, we'll be learning about lightning forms--phenomena that are particularly interesting here on the coast.

_As the teacher continues, *Mac* glances across the room at *ASHER* (10). The two exchange knowing looks.

SCENE 21: EXT. SCHOOL YARD - AFTERNOON

School has just let out, and students are pouring out of the building. *Mac* spots *MAKAYLA* (12) waiting near the edge of the playground. She walks up to him, a serious expression on her face.

MAKAYLA

Can I trust you?

MAC

Yeah.

Makayla looks around cautiously before speaking.

MAKAYLA

Do you know about history - secret professors - tales of promises of the old? A long time ago, there was a group of professors who started a secret society - they were from Yale but they lived in Branford - okay - anyway - They would search these exact coasts - for specific crustaceans that they would find on specific rocks, during a certain time of the season, which is now.

MAC

Why are you telling me this?

MAKAYLA

Because we have to be certain-- that we get the right bait.

MAC

Bait for what?

MAKAYLA

The creature.

SCENE 22: EXT. CORNER BEACH - DUSK

The golden light of the setting sun bathes the beach in a warm glow. *Makayla, Asher, and Mac* arrive with flashlights and ziplock bags. They begin collecting small crustaceans from the rocks, carefully placing them in the bags with a bit of seawater.

Makayla finds *Mac* alone and begins to talk to him.

MAC and *MAKAYLA* sit on a driftwood log, the silence between them heavy. The distant sound of waves fills the air.

MAKAYLA

(after a long silence)

What happened to your mom?

MAC

(speaking softly)

She died a long time ago. She got sick when I was two... and died when I was three.

MAKAYLA

That's cool - my mom too - *(pause)* - so Why did you move here?

MAC

My dad got a job at Yale.

MAKAYLA

What does your dad do?

MAC

He does physics and nuclear theoretical stuff.

MAKAYLA

He doesn't talk much does he.

MAC

No

MAKAYLA

He see's things doesn't he? Things that arent there?

_Mac doesn't respond - a long break.

The atmosphere is tense. Strange, wild sounds echo in the distance, like coyotes letting loose - and howling from far - and then close.

ASHER

What was that?

The kids freeze, glancing around. MAKAYLA grabs out a small audio recorder that she has - and motions for the rest of the crew to stay silent - but after the second cry - without a word, they quickly gather their things and rush to their bikes.

SCENE 23: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Mac pedals home as fast as he can, the events of the evening still fresh in his mind. When he arrives, he sees Dallas outside, watching the bird feeder sway with the wind.

Without hesitation, Mac runs to him and gives him a hug.

Dallas turns toward his son. And for a moment embrace - whilst doing so - they both hear the strange sound together--carried on the wind from the direction of the beach. Dallas looks out into the darkness, his concern growing._

SCENE 24: INT. NEW HOUSE - DINING ROOM - NIGHT

Dallas and *Mac* sit down on their couch for dinner. Tension lingers, and they eat quietly. The distant sounds of the night mix with the clatter of utensils, adding to the growing sense of unease.

On the TV is the *WEATHERMAN* - talking about how some hurricane quickly making headway along the southern coast, and how it is hurricane season. He urges viewers to be on the lookout.

FADE OUT.

WEDNESDAY

SCENE 25A EXT. OUTSIDE MORNING

Dallas and *Mac* walk there dog. They walk it by a patch of grass - tall grass - and *Dallas* looks off into the distance - *Mac* watches his gaze - and soon does the Dog - the latter too now staring at the great no where - beneath the tall grass.

SCENE 25: EXT. DRIVEWAY - EVENING

DALLAS and *MAC* drive to a neighbor's house for dinner. The radio plays in the background.

RADIO ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

And now for your evening weather forecast. Expect clear skies tonight with a slight breeze. Perfect weather for the upcoming Branford Sea Harvest Festival next week. Don't miss out on this annual extravaganza!

SCENE 26: EXT. MOLLY'S BACKYARD DECK

PARTY - EVENING

The setting sun bathes the backyard in a golden glow. Laughter and sizzling BBQ sounds fill the air as neighbors mingle on the deck. *DALLAS* stands with *DOMINIC*, an animated neighbor who's talking enthusiastically.

DOMINIC

(gesturing with a fork full of ziti)

Yeah, yeah, Hugo--my cousin--throws an annual charity event every summer. You'd really like him--his daughter's into all that sea stuff too. You and your son should join us. The kids can play, and we can all hang out.

DOMINIC

(chuckling, gesturing with his fork)

You know, it's wild that we're having this on a Wednesday, right? But that's just how our schedules are these days. Everyone's away on the weekends, picking apples and whatnot. We've got to squeeze in as many BBQs as we can while we still have breath in our lungs!

(takes a bite of ziti, then continues)

I mean, who knows when the next storm might hit, or when life might throw us a curveball? So we gather when we can, break bread together, and enjoy these moments. That's what community's all about, isn't it?

Dallas smiles politely, but seems a bit overwhelmed by Dominic's energy. Mac stands nearby, quietly listening but not engaging, his eyes occasionally drifting to the edge of the backyard.

MAKAYLA (12) approaches Dominic, hugging him quickly. She then steps back, looking over at Mac as she adjusts her backpack straps.

MAKAYLA

(to Dominic)

Dad, I'm heading to the back with the others. I'll be back later.

DOMINIC

Okay, just stay close. We're about to eat. We've got clam chowder that'll warm your soul, lobster rolls bursting with flavor, and a seafood boil with shrimp, clams, and mussels straight from the Sound. And don't miss the stuffed clams and the corn on the cob, all seasoned to perfection. Oh, and save room for the blueberry pie - it's a local legend!

MAKAYLA

Yes, Dad.

Makayla glances at Mac, making brief eye contact before turning and heading toward the far end of the backyard. She disappears into the twilight, silhouetted against the setting sun.

Dallas watches her leave, sensing something in the air, but doesn't say anything. Dominic resumes his animated conversation.

DOMINIC

So this charity event...

SCENE 27: EXT. MOLLY'S FAR BACKYARD BY THE COAST - AFTERNOON

The deck party continues in the distance. MAC wanders alone near the far end of Molly's backyard, which stretches to the coast.

Mac stands still, staring at the water. Waves crash against the rocks. He scans the grass, looking for mysterious eyes, then back to Makayla, who's pointing a telescope at the coastline.

Suddenly, a faint whimper--like an animal in pain--echoes from the wilderness. Nautical sounds engulf him, heightening his fear. The grass rustles, but it's unclear if it's wind or something else.

Frightened, Mac steps back, ready to return to the party. But before he can leave, a group of kids emerges from the fog-- MOLLY, ASHER, and others, including MISTY (13). They move purposefully, faces serious.

Makayla steps forward, focusing on Mac.

MAKAYLA

(firm, yet urgent)

Mac, give me that shovel.

Mac hesitates, then nods and grabs a nearby shovel. As he hands it over, Makayla turns to the group, her expression shifting to leadership.

MAKAYLA

(lowering her voice)

Alright, we move quickly. Asher, you're on the lookout on the outer banks. Misty, you are on the handling of all aspects bait. Set the traps near the tall grass and make sure the cameras are rolling - Mac - you have

to make sure the cameras are rolling too - there will be multiple cameras - and we all will be rolling.

The other kids nod, following Molly's lead. Mac watches, intrigued and nervous.

MAKAYLA

(softly, reassuring)

You there Mac, Mac?

Mac takes a deep breath and nods.

MAKAYLA

Alright.

The kids, led by Makayla, move deeper into the tall grass, toward the tallest grass where the coast drops off into the sea. The fog thickens, and the air grows colder.

SCENE 28: EXT. TALL GRASS THICKET

The crew hang around the tallgrass - it gets thicker and thicker

The crew searches the corner beach for evidence of lightning strikes and burn marks. They find nothing.

_Makayla takes out a steak from Asher's backpack and puts it in the ground - Mac digs the shovel - and Asher slowly brings the baitfish over and puts it in the bucket.

JOCYLEN

How do we know this isn't just a racoon or a coyote eating this?

MAKAYLA

(ignoring this)

They are likely to smell the baitfish between tides.
The wind is steady - this is good.

_ Mac and Asher diligently set up cameras on the surrounding trees - they hook cables up to a battery pack taped onto a wooden panel.

SCENE 29: EXT. THE HIDEAWAY - LATE AFTERNOON

The kids gather at their hideaway--a makeshift fort hidden in Makayla's backyard old playground set - grass. Inside, houses a rudimentary surveillance system: several old LCD Monitors, are propped up against rocks and driftwood, their screens glowing in the dim light. Cables stretch out towards to a jury-rigged power supply--a large battery bank cobbled together from old car batteries and solar chargers.

_ ASHER fiddles with the wiring, his tongue sticking out in concentration as he ensures each screen is properly connected. MISTY arranges the screens in a semicircle, angling them for the best view of their makeshift command center. The setup is far from professional, with duct tape holding wires in place and a tangle of charging cables snaking across the fort's floor, but it's impressive.

MAKAYLA

The creatures are likely to smell the bait fish .

JEFFERSON

How do you know that?

_ They exchange glances.

MISTY

(setting up a camera)

LThe wind Jefferson - the Wnd

Makayla watches Misty set up an old digital point-and-shoot camera while the rest prepare the bait, waiting for the thunderstorm.

JEFFERSON

We got to go back soon.

MAKAYLA

(frowning at the screens)

Asher, the camera feed isn't working.

Asher leans over, squinting at the screen.

He taps a few buttons, but the screen remains black.

MAKAYLA

What is it?

Mac watches Makayla - and off in the distance - he hears a little noise - that it seems like only he could hear - he looks out the window glances at the darkening sky, a hint of worry in his voice.

MAKAYLA

Mac what is it?

MAKAYLA

What do you see?

Makayla looks torn, glancing between the malfunctioning equipment and her friends.

MAKAYLA

But we haven't seen anything yet. We can't just give up.

JEFFERSON

(standing up)

My mom's gonna freak if I'm not home soon. We should probably go.

The group exchanges uncertain looks. Misty checks her watch and sighs.

MISTY

Yeah, we better pack up. We can try again another night when the tech's working.

Reluctantly, they begin to gather their things. Makayla lingers, staring out at the tall grass with a mix of disappointment and determination. _As they pack up their makeshift surveillance system, the wind picks up, rustling through the grass. For a moment, it almost sounds like whispers carried on the breeze.

MISTY

Jefferson - - Mom says we have to go back to the party.

MAKAYLA

No--he actually did.

JEFFERSON

Okay that makes sense now.

MISTY

Jefferson, we have to go back - mom just texted me we got to go now.

SCENE 30: INT. NEIGHBOR'S HOUSE - HALLWAY - EVENING

The kids return to the party. Mac approaches Dallas, who's standing alone in the hallway, looking at wall-mounted family portraits--photos of when the kids were little. He looks at his son and smiles.

DOMINIC

Where were you guys?

FADE OUT.

THURSDAY

SCENE 31: INT. HOUSE - MORNING

Dallas begins to go inside, the sound of the breeze from the Long Island Sound rustling through the trees. He pauses, looking out at the sky before stepping through the door. From the corner of his eye - he spots a burn mark near the mailbox. Dallas walks over and stands over it for a good while.

SCENE 32: EXT. SCHOOL PLAYGROUND - AFTERNOON

Later that afternoon at recess, Mac finds Makayla standing by the soccer net, staring at some strange burn marks on the grass. She turns to him, her expression serious.

MAKAYLA

Have you noticed that the dogs in this town are acting up?

ASHER

Acting Up?

MAKAYLA

Acting up.

Mac hesitates but then nods.

MAKAYLA

Mac - Asher and I are going to come by later this afternoon and set up more traps.

ASHER

Don't we have Youth Group today?

MAKAYLA

Crap.

SCENE 33: INT. YOUTH GROUP CLASS - AFTERNOON

Mac looks around and notices that some of his classmates are also his Sunday School classmates. The *Youth Pastor* begins handing out papers on the topic of ancient Israelites and what we can learn from their mistaken ways of seeking atonement.

The group sit around in a circle and play basic board games - and getting to know you ice breakers.

MAKAYLA

Pastor Jerry - have you noticed what is going on with the Weather?

After the class, the *Youth Pastor* notices *Mac* sitting alone and goes over to console him.

SCENE 34: EXT. CHURCH PARKING LOT

Mac sits alone as the rest of the kids' parents pick them up from Youth Group. He watches everyone and their families go into their various mini vans.

The *Youth Pastor* notices *Mac* sitting alone and joins him on the stoop.

JERRY

Mac, you seem deep in thought. Can I sit?

MAC

Yeah.

JERRY

Is your Dad coming to pick you up?

MAC

Yeah.

JERRY

That's good - that's good. First week - new town - new school - how's it going?

MAC

Good.

JERRY

Ah - that's good...

A group of seagulls fly overhead.

JERRY

(CONT'D)

Yeah - I remember coming here from Georgia - wasn't used to these New England winters. But that was a while ago.

Mac continues to look onward.

MAC

Do you think there are creatures in other worlds?

JERRY

What's that?

MAC

The handout you gave before - and the talk after - you said that the

_ CAME FROM _
to serve God.

JERRY

I did - yes.

MAC

So are there still creatures in this world?

JERRY

Hmmm. Well, maybe you could think of the creatures of the deep waters that we're still figuring out. (MORE)

JERRY

(CONT'D)

I think it's easy for us to get hung up on the logistics - - but if you think about it there are still - - ancient things - things we don't understand - we're discovering about dinosaurs and whatnot.

MAC

That's not what I mean. Makayla was talking about these creatures that she has been seeing in the tall grass - and now her and Asher and me are taking pictures of the tall grass.

JERRY

Makayla is interesting huh - she's come a long way since her father died.

MAC

I thought it was her grandfather that died.

JERRY

Is that what she said?

Dallas approaches and walks outside. He goes up to Jerry and shakes his hand.

DALLAS

Sorry I was late - thank you -

Mac walks into the car.

SCENE 35: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

That night, *Mac* steps outside and sees *Dallas* grilling. The smoke from the grill rises and catches the light, casting

eerie shadows. *Mac* looks beyond the borders of their property, his gaze fixated on the tall grass swaying in the breeze.

Dallas notices him staring and follows his gaze, looking at the tall grass as well.

SCENE 36: INT. MAC'S HOUSE - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Later, *Mac* walks back inside to find *Dallas* staring at the weather TV. *Dallas* notices *Mac* and gets up. The two sit together by the TV. Off in the distance - the wind pulls up.

SCENE 37: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

That night, as they prepare for bed, a strange sound echoes through the house. The wind begins to pick up, rattling the windows. *Dallas* looks out into the night, the tall grass swaying ominously.

SCENE 38: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Dallas steps outside into the thunderstorm to make sure everything is secure. The wind howls around him as he checks the perimeter, a sense of unease settling in.

FADE OUT.

FRIDAY

SCENE 39: INT. MAC'S HOUSE - MORNING

The next morning, the storm has passed, but the air is still heavy with the remnants of the previous night's events. *DALLAS* looks out the window and finds the seed from the bird feeder scattered about. *MAC* searches for the rocks they had collected earlier.

SCENE 40: INT. SCHOOL CLASSROOM - DAY

The *TEACHER* stands at the front of the class, addressing the students.

TEACHER

Not sure if you folks have been noticing, but the weather has been acting sporadic lately. Johnny, can you spell 'sporadic' for me?

SCENE 41: EXT. BEACH ROAD - SATURDAY MORNING

The crew goes wild with their bikes down the road, past the post office, riding along the tiny coastal sidewalks. The wind whips through their hair as they pedal furiously, their laughter carried away by the sea breeze.

SCENE 42: INT. SCHOOL MEDIA LAB - AFTERNOON

The crew--*MAKAYLA*, *MAC*, and a few other kids--gather around a computer. They stand over a software editor, DaVinci Resolve, going frame by frame through various camera footage, scanning for any sign of eyes or other mysterious figures. *MISTY* hands *MAKAYLA* another camera, and she inserts its SD card into the computer.

Nothing unusual comes up on the screen.

JEFFERSON

(to Makayla)

Hey, you showed Mac that dumb book yet?

Makayla shoots Jefferson a warning glance, silencing him.

MAKAYLA

No.

MAC

What book?

MAKAYLA

Never mind.

ASHER

(to Mac)

It's the book our grandfather wrote.

MAC

What?

MAKAYLA

It's the book our grandfather wrote.

MAC

What?

MAKAYLA

Never mind.

AUTHORS NOTE

FLESH OUT THIS SCENE

SATURDAY #2

SCENE 43: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - MORNING

DALLAS is outside, focused on building a bird feeder. He examines his creation, then turns his attention to a bucket filled with gardening supplies. Initially hesitant, he eventually begins tending to the garden.

MAC rummages through the bucket, discovering an old fishing wire and a ring. He fashions a makeshift ring toss game on a tree across from the tall grass.

Mac plays for a while, then retrieves his bike and rides off.

SCENE 44: EXT. MAKAYLA'S HOUSE - MORNING

Mac parks his bike outside Makayla and Asher's home. *DOMINIC*, the talkative neighbor, answers the door.

DOMINIC

Oh, what's up Mr. Mac - what's shaking my friend? How's your dad?

MAC

He's okay.

DOMINIC

You should tell him to call me sometime. You looking for Makayla?

MAC

Yeah - I have her *Item.

Makayla comes running down the stairs, arms full of laptops, camcorders, and various electronic equipment.

SCENE 45: INT. MAKAYLA'S GRANDPA'S STUDY - DAY

The room is cluttered with old DVD covers, playhouses, and dust-covered blankets concealing books and chests. *Makayla*, *Mac*, and *Asher* huddle around a dusty laptop with basic movie editing software.

MAKAYLA

(whispering) I was thinking we could triangulate the creature.

MAC

How do you know all of this?

MAKAYLA

Can I trust you?

Makayla retrieves an old, leather-bound journal from a shelf. She begins reading aloud from an entry dated 1925, describing her grandfather's encounter with strange creatures in the woods.

MAKAYLA

(reading) "Cold - summer night in September - Wednesday - 1925 - cold windy - outside - near the coast - far off in the distance I stood with my father - and we both saw the stones..."

As Makayla continues reading, the wind outside picks up.

MAC

I think I should go home.

MAKAYLA

What do you mean?

ASHER

It's getting windy.

MAC

My dad's been worried about the weather.

MAKAYLA

(determined, closing the journal) We have to find out what happened next. If Grandpa saw them, then we can too. We just need to figure out what they want... before it's too late. I think they want the chicken on the stick.

MAC

Okay - when do you want to do this?

MAKAYLA

We have to wait on the weather - for a true thunderstorm.

SCENE 46: EXT. MAC'S BIKE RIDE HOME

Mac rides his bike along the tall grass, scanning for eyes. He notices a dog in the distance acting strangely, barking at the tall grass. *Mac* speeds up.

SCENE 47: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - OUTSIDE GARAGE

Mac finds *Dallas* outside taking weather measurements. *Dallas* explains how it works.

In the distance, a camera crew is filming something in the tall grass. Mac, curious, walks over to investigate. He spots another gemstone on the ground but doesn't touch it.

SCENE 48: INT. MAC'S HOUSE - DINNER TIME

Mac and Dallas eat dinner while watching TV. News reports discuss the approaching hurricane and "hurricane season."

Mac looks out the window, searching for eyes in the tall grass. He sees a flicker in the night.

That night, as the wind howls, Mac's gaze wanders across the street to the tall grass.

SUNDAY #2

SCENE 49: INT. CHURCH SANCTUARY

The church is buzzing with talk of the town - apparently a very strange event happened to everything the night before.

Mac looks at different congregates hovering around a coffee pot as an older gentleman hands out welcome cards. On the screen there are announcements for the upcoming Harvest Festival - the church is going to be a part of it and run the kids crafts table - volunteers are needed.

Mac and Dallas walk into the pew and sit behind a baby that stares at Mac.

The piano begins.

PASTOR JERRY

Please find a seat - our call to worship this morning is from the book of Isaiah - Chapter 52 verse 25.

The projector screen displays the verse.

Mac looks around for *Makayla* and *Asher* but they are not here this morning.

SCENE 50: EXT. CHURCH OUTSIDE FELLOWSHIP LUNCH

Mac approaches *Jerry* and asks him if he has seen *Makayla* or *Asher*.

MAC

I was with them yesterday.

PASTOR JERRY

They were supposed to help out with the nursery room - all good - just not like their father to not bring them - okay - sorry - just wanted to make sure they were okay.

SCENE 51: EXT. BEACH HOUSE

Mac and *Dallas* approach their home from their walk. *Mac* runs over to the mailbox.

Mac looks around the neighbors' house but sees their car gone.

MONDAY #2

SCENE 52: INT. SCHOOL

Mac checks the stones - they are still there. School begins and ends. The teacher talks about the weather more. *Asher* and *Mac* eat silently during lunch. *Makayla's* father takes them home.

Mac goes home that night and sees *Makayla* sitting alone.

SCENE 53: EXT. MAKAYLA'S HOUSE

MAKAYLA

I saw the creature last night.

Mac's eyes widen.

MAKAYLA

It came.

Mac's eyes widen again.

MAKAYLA

Asher's in the hospital.

MAC

Really?

MAKAYLA

We were going to get the footage before it got dark - and as we were approaching the camera - He saw the creature too and he ran away and he broke his leg - I stood there and stood still... we were there until late - and I was tired so I asked my dad if I could stay home from school today and he said it was okay - he took off work himself - Asher's in the hospital and we're going to go over after we shower and visit him - he should be back tomorrow.

MAC

Have you talked to him?

No - not really - I told him not to talk about what we were doing back there - as the adults would think would get all worried and start a big investigation and ruin our plans before they begin.

MAC

What do you see?

MAKAYLA

I saw eyes in the distance... And then - and then I don't know what happened - it was like - I was dreaming for a second - but then I woke up and it was gone - and Asher was crying in the distance.

MAC

Did you look at the footage?

Makayla Smiles.

CUT TO

SCENE 54: INT. HALF-FINISHED BASEMENT COMPUTER ROOM

The crew look at a series of old CRT era laptops all haphazardly and hackerdly arranged - and then a big slow motion - and then nothing - and then Asher crying - but a flash of light - and in the center as they zoom nothing - but as a filter is applied - some makeshift eyes appear.

The dad comes downstairs and tells Makayla that they have to go - Mac needs to go home.

CUT TO

SCENE 55: EXT. MAC HOUSE

Dallas is out in the front yard looking at the gemstones and then he looks at *Mac* - *Mac* looks back - the two walk inside and check the weather.

TUESDAY #2

SCENE 56: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - MORNING

School has been cancelled. DALLAS turns on the TV.

TV ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Due to the impending hurricane, all schools in the area will be closed today. The storm is expected to make landfall...

MAC looks out the window, seeing a bright sunny sky. MAKAYLA and ASHER arrive on bikes.

MAKAYLA

Can we use your sink?

SCENE 57: INT. MAC'S KITCHEN

DALLAS stands over the sink, washing dirt off potatoes. He moves aside as MAKAYLA storms in.

MAKAYLA takes out an old metal instrument and begins washing dirt off of it.

MAKAYLA

(rattling on) I have a plan. I think the creatures have landed. I believe they've come with the storm. Now, we're going to mark them.

DALLAS putters around, looking for a towel to dry his hands.

MAKAYLA hands MAC the wet instrument. DALLAS hands MAC a cloth.

MAKAYLA and DALLAS lock eyes. ASHER bumps into them, carrying a box of meat thermometers.

SCENE 58: EXT. MAC'S BACKYARD

MAKAYLA demonstrates to MAC, ASHER, and DALLAS how to plant a device in the ground.

MAKAYLA (V.O.)

Creatures, like animals, give off heat... These are set to pick up temperature changes in the ground.

MAKAYLA pulls out an electrical device. DALLAS picks it up, inspecting it.

ASHER

Does it work?

DALLAS looks concerned, takes it to his workshop.

MAKAYLA

He's going to fix it, right? I think that one works. He'll figure it out. Here's another. *(tosses a trail cam to MAC)* It's a trail cam. When we get notice of ground temperature changes, we'll know when to look for footage. Grade A stuff - they detect night vision and anything else.

MAC

Where do you want to hang them?

SCENE 59: EXT. MAC'S BACKYARD - THE TREE

MAC uses his fishing line kit to tie down a device.

SCENE 60: EXT. MAKAYLA'S BACKYARD

MAC hangs another deer cam. ASHER plants meat thermometers near the tall grass.

MAKAYLA (V.O.)

The creatures give off heat - just like any other creatures.

SCENE 61: EXT. NEIGHBORHOOD

The kids ride bikes. MAKAYLA scouts locations. ASHER and MAC ride together.

ASHER

Do you think there are really creatures in the tall grass?

MAC

(Looking at Asher) Do you?

ASHER

I think so. Makayla seems to think so, at least.

SCENE 62: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - DUSK

The children arrive. DALLAS comes out with the fixed device, handing it to MAKAYLA. They exchange looks. MAKAYLA and ASHER ride off.

MAC and DALLAS go inside silently. DALLAS resumes washing potatoes.

SCENE 63: INT. MAC'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

MAC stares at glow-in-the-dark stars on his ceiling, then at a picture of his mom.

A faint cry, like a wounded animal, is heard in the distance, then stops.

MAC looks out the window at the tall grass. He sees nothing at first, then spots eyes.

He retreats to bed, then looks out again. Nothing.

Another cry is heard, followed by a loud crash.

SCENE 64: INT. MAC'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

MAC stands at his bedroom window, peering out into the darkness. The moonlight casts eerie shadows across the backyard. From his vantage point, he can see the BURN MARKS on the ground, scattered near the tall grass, more numerous than before.

His eyes scan the dark horizon, searching. For the briefest moment, GLOWING EYES appear between the swaying grass. MAC's breath catches in his throat. He blinks, and the eyes are gone. Was it real, or just his imagination?

Another faint cry echoes in the distance, sending a shiver down MAC's spine. He leans closer to the window, pressing his forehead against the cool glass.

Suddenly, the motion-activated porch light flicks on, startling MAC. He sees DALLAS step out onto the porch, looking around with a concerned expression.

MAC quickly ducks away from the window, his heart racing. He climbs back into bed, pulling the covers up to his chin. As he lies there in the dark, he can't shake the feeling that something out there is watching them.

WEDNESDAY #2

AUTHOR'S NOTE

This scene is a bit of a mess - I'm not sure how to write it. - From Here it gets very GPT

That morning is a long one to school. Mac and Dallas are silent as they drive past the windy hills and seaside coast.

SCENE 65: INT. SCHOOL - KITCHEN

The school is buzzing with the news of the creatures. The kids are whispering and pointing at Mac and Dallas as they enter.

Mac and *Dallas* sit at a table with *Makayla* and *Asher*.

MAKAYLA

We have to do it tonight. You've heard the forecast.

MAC

I know.

ASHER

We're going to be stuck in this metal box with a bunch of dead batteries.

MAKAYLA

What?

ASHER

The thermometers - they're dead.

MAC

I know.

MAKAYLA

We're going to be stuck in this metal box with a bunch of dead batteries.

MAC

I know.

MAKAYLA

We have to do it tonight.

MAC

I know.

SCENE 66: INT. SCHOOL - SUBSTITUE TEACHER

The classroom is unusually quiet as Mac and Asher walk in. They notice a stranger standing at the front of the room, a SUBSTITUTE TEACHER, who is fumbling with the attendance sheet.

SUBSTITUTE TEACHER

(nervously)

Good morning, class. I'm Mr. Thompson, and I'll be your substitute teacher today.

The students exchange curious glances. Mac and Asher take their seats, whispering to each other.

The substitute teacher clears his throat, trying to gain the class's attention.

SUBSTITUTE TEACHER

Alright, let's get started. Today, we'll be continuing with your weather patterns lesson.

Mac and Asher exchange a look.

SCENE 67: INT. ASHER'S HOUSE - LATE AFTERNOON

Asher's house is filled with the sound of the storm approaching. The wind howls outside as Makayla arrives,

carrying a backpack full of supplies. She knocks on the door, and Asher quickly lets her in.

ASHER

Did you bring everything?

MAKAYLA

Yeah, it's all here. We need to set up the trap before it gets any worse out there.

They move to the living room, where they spread out the contents of Makayla's backpack: ropes, stakes, and a few homemade devices.

ASHER

Are you sure this is going to work?

MAKAYLA

It has to. We don't have any other choice.

They work quickly, setting up the trap near the back door. The wind outside grows stronger, rattling the windows.

ASHER

What if the storm gets too bad?

MAKAYLA

Then we'll have to be extra careful. But we can't wait any longer. The creatures are coming, and we need to be ready.

Asher nods, determination in his eyes. They finish setting up the trap and double-check everything.

MAKAYLA

Alright, let's go over the plan one more time.

They huddle together, going over the details of their plan as the storm rages outside.

ASHER

We can do this.

MAKAYLA

We have to.

They share a determined look, ready to face whatever comes their way.

Dallas comes outside and sees what they are doing. Dallas steps outside, noticing the kids setting up the traps. He watches them for a moment, then silently approaches, his presence unnoticed at first.

Asher and Makayla are focused on their task, unaware of Dallas's approach. He quietly picks up a stake and a rope, examining their setup.

MAKAYLA

Make sure the ropes are tight. We can't afford any mistakes.

Asher nods, tightening a knot. Dallas steps in, securing another stake into the ground with practiced ease. The kids look up, surprised to see him there.

As the wind howls louder, Dallas checks the stability of their setup, making sure everything is in place. He hands Makayla a rope, and she ties it down, her confidence growing with his support.

The kids nod, their resolve strengthened by his presence. As the storm continues to rage, they prepare to face the creatures, knowing they have Dallas's silent support.

SCENE 68: EXT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

The house is dark and Mac and Dallas have dinner. Mac begins to talk about the creatures.

MAC

Dad... Do you think this is all real?

DALLAS

It could be.

MAC

Do you think we're ready?

DALLAS

I think we'll catch something.

MAC

What if we don't?

DALLAS

Then we'll won't.

MAC

Dad... Have you seen the eyes?

Dallas pauses, his expression serious. He looks at Mac, considering his words carefully.

DALLAS

There is something out there.

Mac's eyes widen, a mix of fear and curiosity.

MAC

What do you think they are?

DALLAS

Something we might have to address...

Mac nods, feeling a sense of reassurance from his father's words. The bond between them strengthens as they prepare for the unknown.

CUT TO

SCENE 69: INT. MAC'S HOUSE - NIGHT

_Dallas and Mac go into overdrive mode - preparing the house. They board up the windows and the stakes. TV Reporter: Evacuations are underway - but are limited in scope focusing on the northern regions - for the southern regions - it is advise that people stay in their homes and board up any long - head for a basement.

Mac and Dallas sit in the living room, the glow of the TV casting shadows on their faces. Suddenly, Mac's phone rings. He looks at the screen and sees it's a FaceTime call from Makayla._

AUTHOR'S NOTE

Need to think of the tension and Makayla's call.

THURSDAY #2